



Home advantage: For someone starting their rally journey, domestic competitions present a great opportunity to learn the nature of this sport, feels Gaurav. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Considering how difficult the world of rallying is, how important are homegrown competitions like the INRC?

The INRC is a great grassroot-level of rallying. By far, we have the best early network programme in Asia right now. The number of teams and people competing is ten times higher compared to other countries. But those who participate in the regional championships will be up for a big shock when they go to something like the European Rally Championship or WRC.

The competition levels are extremely difficult. Even the level of the racetracks here is probably not even half as good compared to what we run in WRC. There is still a long way to go, but for someone starting

their rally journey, it's a great opportunity to learn the nature of this sport.

Despite the rapid strides that rally racing has taken over the years, is the sport still considered niche?

I would say it's still niche, but it's growing in very large numbers, and quickly. The events we currently have in India feature almost 70 to 80 competitors and teams — by far the biggest in Asia. It shows that this is the fastest-growing motorsport discipline in India.

The ecosystem is focused on the domestic scene right now. But the government and the federation (FMSCI) should get together and consider at least waiving all the import costs for us.

Right now, for any small part being imported, we pay around 30–45 per cent. So, for equipment worth Rs.10 lakh, the price automatically becomes Rs.14 lakh.

That becomes a big challenge, apart from the equipment and the

cars. The purchase cost and everything else are completely different — that's a big disadvantage for us.

What is necessary to produce a consistent pipeline of world-class racers across disciplines?

We need manufacturing support to begin with — full-time support from car and bike manufacturers at a larger level, where they understand how much R&D (research and development) can help, beyond just sales and marketing.

There are already so many countries that waive this, including those in Africa. With the costs and huge money involved, this country does not see it as a very high return-on-investment sport.

India is going to be the third-largest automotive market in the world soon. And when the country, along with the federation, helps reduce some of these costs — our biggest obstacle — that's when the sport is really going to kick off.